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BATTLE STATIONS
(Left) A joint army-IAF exercise in Jalandhar, Apr. 25; a Pak Army tank being moved in Muridke, May 7

WHILE IT SUITS CHINA FOR INDIA TO BE TIED DOWN IN A COMBAT WITH PAKISTAN, IT WOULD NOT WANT THE CONFLICT TO BECOME A NUCLEAR ONE AND MAY ADVISE PAKISTAN TO DE-ESCALATE

Turkey to boost its drone and electronic warfare capabilities. It has, for instance, acquired two advanced Turkish drones from Baykar—the Bayraktar TB2 and the Bayraktar Akinci. Featuring a 40,000-foot service ceiling, over 25-hour endurance, 7,500 km range and AESA radar for air-to-air and air-to-ground missions, the Akinci, operated by the 64th Combat Unmanned Aerial System Squadron at the Murid air base, has considerably boosted Pakistan's ISR (intelligence, surveillance and reconnaissance) and strike capabilities. In its initial strikes, therefore, Pakistan has relied heavily on sending swarms of drones to attack Indian military and civilian targets.

What India Should Do

Maj. Gen. A.P. Singh (retd), who served extensively on the LoC (Line of Control) during his career, counsels that India's strategy should be multifaceted and calibrated for both defensive resilience and an offensive precision approach. "The first priority," he says, "is to maintain a firm hold along the LoC, where the terrain is challenging and Pakistani forces are heavily deployed with fortified defences, making major incursions unlikely and costly." Simultaneously, he adds, India should retain pre-designated target lists for calibrated aerial and naval strikes, enabling rapid execution of precision attacks if required. Hooda says, "We have a conventional superiority over Pakistan that we should exploit. The LoC terrain is more difficult, with Pakistan able to build up forces to match ours, so we should spread the battlefield to the International Border (IB) where we have large open areas and we can achieve some success." Given the Indian navy's superiority, other experts say India should impose a naval blockade alongside the land thrust on the IB and then pressure Pakistan to sue for peace. Overall, while India's logistical edge and air-naval dominance could subdue Pakistan swiftly, their nuclear arsenal can cast a shadow over limited conflicts.

Simultaneously, India should push for the international community to rein in Pakistan. The escalation could not have come at a more inopportune time for India with most nations grappling with the worldwide storm US president Donald Trump has unleashed in global trade and tariffs. Despite its preoccupation with Pakistan, India smartly signed a landmark free trade agreement with the UK on May 6, and is negotiating hard with both the US and Europe to arrive at trade agreements. These moves have ensured that major world powers, save China, will side with it as it takes on Pakistan.

The Trump administration is aligned with India, though it is pushing both countries not to escalate tensions. As is Europe. China has so far backed Pakistan and is expected to extend all manner of covert support in terms of electronic warfare capabilities and intelligence, besides the supply of spares and additional ammunition that Pakistan may need. While it is in Beijing's interest to keep India engaged in combating Pakistan and take its eyes off the larger ambition of challenging it in the Indian Ocean, China will not want the conflict to escalate into a nuclear confrontation. Rudra Chaudhari, Director, Carnegie India, says, "The US is likely to tell India that they do not want any instability in South Asia and push Delhi to open lines of communication with Pakistan. China, too, is likely to counsel Pakistan to move towards de-escalating the situation." That remains India's best bet to cool temperatures while delivering a strong message to Pakistan that communicates its zero tolerance for terrorism. ■